

Far-right party influence on polarization dynamics in electoral campaign

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Abstract

Political polarization has attracted increasing attention in recent years, driven by the rise of social media and the global emergence of far-right populist movements. This study investigates the dynamics of structural polarization during electoral campaigns in multi-party systems, with a particular focus on the presence of far-right actors and their influence on polarization patterns and hate speech. Using retweet networks as a measure of structural polarization, we analyze two case studies in Spain: the 2022 Andalusia regional elections, where the far-right party Vox was a significant contender, and the 2019 Barcelona city council elections, where the party had no representation. Our results reveal that the presence of a far-right party intensifies polarization, leading to the formation of two distinct ideological blocks aligned along left-right ideological axes, as observed in Andalusia. In contrast, the Catalan independence movement in Barcelona diluted the alignment of voters, resulting in a more complex, multi-axis polarization landscape. We also explore the relationship between polarization and hate speech, finding an anti-correlation between them in both cases. Our findings underscore the significant role of far-right movements in driving political polarization and the nuanced effects of different political contexts on polarization dynamics.

Keywords: polarization, hate speech, electoral campaign, far-right

1 Introduction

The study of political and ideological polarization has garnered significant attention from both academics and the general public since the early 1990s (DiMaggio et al., 1996). This interest has been particularly intense in the United States, where polarization has been closely associated with the more general phenomena of Culture Wars, that have shaped political discourse over the past few decades. Some scholars argue that the end of the Cold War disrupted the broad consensus that had previously underpinned political stability, contributing to the rise in polarization together with the rise of the religious right (Du Mez, 2023). In recent years, the focus on this issue has been revitalized by the global emergence of populist far-right movements, such as Donald Trump’s election as U.S. President in 2016, and by the widespread adoption of social media.

While social media platforms provide an invaluable lens through which to observe political and ideological polarization, there is no scientific consensus on whether social media use itself has a polarising effect (Acerbi, 2019). Several studies, including Del Vicario et al. (2016), have reported empirical evidence suggesting that platforms like Facebook and Twitter contribute to increased polarization. However, other research such as that of Tucker et al. (2018), has either failed to find such an effect or has even pointed in the opposite direction, indicating that the relationship between social media use and polarization is complex and context and topic-dependent (Barberá et al., 2015). Nevertheless, it is widely recognised that political campaigns tend to exacerbate polarization, regardless of the medium through which they are conducted (Hansen and Kosiara-Pedersen, 2017).

Traditionally, measures of polarization have focused on the collective, or distributional, properties of individual attitudes within a society (DiMaggio et al., 1996). Specifically, in the context of political or ideological polarization, these measures examine the distributional properties of public opinion. Among the various operationalisations proposed, the family of measures presented by Esteban and Ray (1994) define polarization as reaching its maximum when a population is divided into two equally sized groups positioned at the greatest possible ideological distance from each other. With the advent of social big data, a range of new measures has emerged to capture polarization dynamics. One such measure is structural polarization, which assesses the extent to which a network of endorsements, such as retweets, splits into two distinct and opposing groups (Salloum et al., 2022). It is also well-established that the retweet mechanism serves as a broadcasting tool, indicating that users who retweet not only endorse the content of the original tweet but also show a significant level of interest, actively opting to share the information with their followers (Martin-Gutierrez et al., 2023). This perspective is common in the Twitter analysis literature, where retweets are viewed as evidence of a user supporting the message of the original poster (Falkenberg et al., 2022). For this reasons, retweets networks are well suited to study polarization.

In two-party systems, such as that of the United States, the increase in polarization during electoral campaigns can be seen as obvious or even trivial, driven by the binary nature of political competition (Olivares et al., 2019). However, in multi-party systems, the emergence and nature of polarization are less straightforward (Hansen

and Kosiara-Pedersen, 2017) and are related to the relation between in-parties and out-parties (Martin-Gutierrez et al., 2024). Electoral campaigns in these contexts can result in a range of outcomes, from block polarization, where parties align into two opposing blocs, to fragmentation or multipolarization (Martin-Gutierrez et al., 2023), where voter attention becomes more evenly dispersed across multiple parties. The predominance of research focused on U.S. data, however, has often led to an overlooking of these complexities, leaving a gap in understanding how polarization manifests in multi-party systems electoral campaigns.

Thus, it is particularly important to study electoral campaigns in political systems where new actors have emerged, especially populist far-right movements. These actors often disrupt traditional party dynamics and can significantly influence patterns of polarization. Furthermore, polarization may or may not be accompanied by an increase in hate speech, making it of interest to explore the relationship between the two. Those frequently employ identity based divisive rhetoric in opposition to emerging political actors previously unrepresented in the political sphere, like feminists, racialised people, and migrants (Proyecto Una, 2019; Nagle, 2017). This can include framing issues in ways that appeal to specific ideological or partisan groups, heightening emotional responses, and demonising opponents (Romero-Rodríguez et al., 2023). That could exacerbate both polarization and the prevalence of hate speech in political discourse (Bjornsgaard and Dukić, 2023).

In this study, we will investigate polarization during electoral campaigns in Spain, that experience the presence of new parties, including a populist far-right one, alongside the other traditional parties. We examine the impact of the presence of a far-right party on polarization from the point of view of the dynamical retweet network. On one hand, we will study the case of the 2022 regional elections in Andalusia, being specially relevant because they were the first elections after the entrance of the far-right party Vox in the parliament of Andalusia. On the other hand, we will examine the case of the 2019 Barcelona City Council elections, where the far-right party had no representation in the city council. Also, we study the relationship between hate speech and polarization during these periods. For simplicity, we will refer to the Andalusia 2022 regional elections dataset to simply Andalusia and for the Barcelona 2019 City Council elections to Barcelona.

1.1 Andalusia 2022 Regional Elections

The 2022 Andalusia Regional Election was held on Sunday, 19 June. These elections select the members of the Parliament of Andalusia, which in turn determines the composition of the *Junta de Andalucía*, the institution that organizes the self-government of the Autonomous Community of Andalusia, in Spain.

In the 2018 elections, for the first time in 36 years, right-wing parties secured a majority, leading to the end of the long-standing dominance of the *Partido Socialista Obrero Español de Andalucía* (PSOE-A). Despite being the most popular party in the region, PSOE-A was replaced in government by a coalition led by Juan Manuel Moreno of the *Partido Popular de Andalucía* (PP). Moreno assumed the presidency, forming an alliance with *Ciudadanos* (Cs), and relying on support from Vox for a confidence and supply arrangement. The main parties and coalitions participating in the 2022